Alpha Centauri, would still be difficult to detect. In our ignorance, the geocentrists find hope.

There was once a scientific hypothesis—not just well received but prevailing—that supposed our solar system to have formed through the near collision of the ancient Sun with another star; the gravitational tidal interaction pulled out tendrils of sunstuff that quickly condensed into planets. Since space is mainly empty and near stellar collisions most rare, it was concluded that few other planetary systems exist—perhaps only one, around that other star that long ago co-parented the worlds of our solar system. Early in my studies, I was amazed and disappointed that such a view had ever been taken seriously, that for planets of other stars, absence of evidence had been considered evidence of absence.

Today we have firm evidence for at least three planets orbiting an extremely dense star, the pulsar designated B1257 + 12, about which I'll say more later. And we've found, for more than half the stars with masses like the Sun's, that early in their careers they're surrounded by great disks of gas and dust out of which planets seem to form. Other planetary systems now look to be a cosmic commonplace, maybe even worlds something like the Earth. We should be able, in the next few decades, to inventory at least the larger planets, if they exist, of hundreds of nearby stars.

Well, if our position in space doesn't reveal our special role, our position in time does: We've been in the Universe since The Beginning (give or take a few days). *We've been given special responsibilities by the Creator*. It once seemed very reasonable to think of the Universe as beginning just a little before our collective memory is obscured by the passage of time and the illiteracy of our ancestors. Generally speaking, that's hundreds or thousands of years ago. Religions that purport to describe the origin of the Universe often specify—implicitly or explicitly—a date of origin of roughly such vintage, a birthday for the world.

If you add up all the "begats" in Genesis, for example, you get an age for the Earth: 6,000 years old, plus or minus a little. The universe is said to be exactly as old as the Earth. This is still the